

BULK BETROTHALS

India's richest religious shrine comes forward to help middle class families who feel daunted by the cost of modern-day weddings

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

This is Balaji's blessing," coo Chandravenu and his coy bride Rajani at Muthyalareddypalle in Chittoor district, almost in chorus.

Like most people in the state's countryside these days, they had also chosen to be part of the unique TTD (Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams) sponsored kalyanamastu (mass marriage ceremony). A wedding in the traditional sense would have cost both families about Rs 1 lakh each, plus the cost of wedding clothes and travel. Another couple, Bhaskar Pillai and Rathnamma are glad that not only are the expenses cut, but the ceremony itself is simple and swift. Several others, ecstatic that their marriages have been conducted by TTD—which manages India's richest shrine of Lord Venkateswara at Tirumala—have decided to name their children after Lord Venkateswara or Goddess Padmavathi, depending on whether they have a daughter or a son. Nothing has caught the imagination of young couples in the state as the mass marriages, which TTD first organised in February 2007. "The poor borrow large sums for marriages and get stuck in debt. With kalyanamastu, they are free now," points out TTD's Executive Officer K.V. Ramanachary.

Kalyanamastu is not just for the indigent. It is also aimed at creating awareness among Hindus to curb wasteful expenditure. Couples who avail the services offered by TTD, get clothes, a mangalsutra (gold chain symbolising wedlock) weighing 2 gm and silver *mettalu* (toe rings) for the bride. Those wanting to get married have to obtain the consent of their parents and register their names in ad-



vance with the local kalyanamastu committee. TTD spends about Rs 7,000 on each couple, which includes arranging for the priests, a band and hosting a vegetarian meal for the guests—restricted to 60 persons for each couple. Thereafter, the newly-weds and the parents of both are given six tickets to visit Tirumala Temple within three months of their marriage.

Kalyanamastu has become popular because it is held simultaneously at 294 places across the state, either at TTD

kalyana mandapams, prominent Hindu temples in its vicinity or open grounds, depending on the number of registered applicants in a place. The mangalsutras gifted to the couples are kept at the feet of the presiding deity at Tirumala during a special prayer and sanctified before their dispatch to the wedding venues.

For those who wish but cannot afford to invite Brahmins to perform their marriage, this TTD initiative is truly Godsend. Amidst Vedic chants, the

"Our goal is direct and simple, protection and propagation of Hindu dharma and ancient traditions."

**B. KARUNAKARA REDDY,
TTD CHAIRMAN**

